

offset the one advantage terrorists have: surprise. If another attack does come, there is a real danger that the NSG will be fighting terrorists with the same equipment they used in Mumbai. The NSG is spending an estimated Rs 2,000 crore on buying land and erecting buildings. The question being asked by NSG officials is: If the current force of nearly 6,000 commandos continues to be ill-equipped, what will be the equipment profile for the nearly 10,000-strong force when it is finally established in these new hubs? There are dangers that the force will become another

paramilitary force rather than the special force it is supposed to be.

Another serious lacunae is that the NSG units are still subject to the gridlock of city traffic in all their hubs. In the event of another Mumbai-type attack, for instance, it will take the NSG over an hour merely to reach South Mumbai from their current location at Kalina in suburban Mumbai. The solution is for dedicated helicopters to rapidly ferry them anywhere in the city in a matter of minutes. But this is not even on the horizon.

by Sandeep Unnithan

AFP PHOTO/ MANAN VATSYAYANA



Intelligence LOOKING SMART

The Multi Agency Centre goes ahead full steam

One of the untold stories of 26/11 is of a brave Jammu and Kashmir policeman who had infiltrated the Lashkar-e-Toiba and planted a set of mobile phone SIM cards which were eventually used by the Mumbai attackers. Not only did the activation of these SIM cards in Mumbai not ring alarm bells but the Kolkata Police arrested the police constable as a terrorist. It was a classic case of the left hand not knowing what the right was doing. Post-26/11, perhaps the biggest achievement has been co-ordination. The Multi Agency Centre (MAC) energised after the attacks, now runs at full strength, coordinating between 23 representatives from the intelligence agencies in the home, defence and finance ministries. State MACs or SMACs have been set up in all the states to encourage intelligence collection and collation from the very grassroots.

Alerts picked up at the field level are instantly transmitted to the MAC in hours. The next stage: powerful mainframes with dedicated software to process the mass of raw intelligence flowing in through the MAC. These computers will form the core of a National Counter Terrorism Centre like its counterpart in the US which Home Minister Chidambaram hopes to replicate in India. The national intelligence grid will throw up matches and generate patterns that would immediately generate suspicion.

by S.U.

WHAT'S DONE

- Intelligence sharing through the MAC has been energised
- Intelligence agencies hold daily meetings
- Coordination among various agencies has become better

WHAT'S NOT

- The manpower of the IB has not increased
- Networked technical infrastructure for faster data transfer has not been acquired
- Coastal security has not been linked with state MACs